

Re: Marriage

By Ellen McGrath Smith

1.

I want to meet Marianne Moore at a ballgame,
toss popcorn in the tubular brim of her tricornered hat,
throw back vats of stadium beer and wax inappropriate
as I often do near statues of statesmen or saints
and say things like "I bet you
need more anesthesia than I do," or "Did you ever dream
of matricide?"

Or, I might try to out-nerd her by keeping a scorecard
while she grips her kneecaps with every twitch
of the home-plate ump, "for he has beauty also;
it's distressing—the O thou to whom from whom
without whom nothing—Adam." I would mention,
"in that quixotic atmosphere of frankness," the fact that,
in 2015, when we watch games on TV, they project
little squares
to show the strike zone for each batter, so the ump
is no longer the First Man, in fact no one is first anything
anymore,
not even the First Lady, "the blue panther with black eyes,
the basalt panther with blue eyes, entirely graceful—"
since, in the blogosphere, the chatter of a thousand bats
invades her hair,
and everyone's a critic and a poet and a preacher,
politician, peddler, "equally positive in demanding
a commotion
and in stipulating quiet." Marianne would do the latter
so she could hear the ballpark breathing and popping,
the numbers on the scoreboard groaning, a "severe
object," the field,
"with a pleasing geometry / stipulating space
not people."

2.

When Moore offered names for those '55 Fords,
the general public viewed her, perhaps, as "a kind of
overgrown cupid
reduced to insignificance by the mechanical advertising
parading as involuntary comment," though, by then,
the virgin and the dynamo had wed on the cover
of *Look* magazine,
with a rearguard of full-color ads clanking from the bumper.

And, besides, her poetry was not a Ford: it was more of a
Bentley ambulance milk truck hearse
with "fire-gilt steel, alive with goldenness."

When William Carlos Williams took a Moore poem
for a spin,
he knew she was someone he couldn't lay, although
"one must not call him ruffian / nor friction a calamity—
the fight to be affectionate"
gathering in his dark come-hither brow as he chewed
on those long lines like licorice, or pulled them like floss
between Ezra Pound's breakless stentorian teeth.
"He has prophesied correctly—the industrious waterfall"
epicized by his recalcitrant imagination, his "Somehow,
it seems to destroy us"
wed to her "strange experience of beauty; its existence
too much;
it tears one to pieces."

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